

Metadata Explanation

The catalogue for this project was developed using a metadata structure grounded in the *Dublin Core Metadata Element Set*, the schema that underpins Omeka and provides a flexible, widely interoperable framework for describing digital cultural heritage objects (Dublin Core Metadata Initiative, 2024; Miller, 2022). While Dublin Core offers broad applicability, its generality can limit the descriptive precision required to document site-specific graffiti. To address this, the catalogue incorporates additional fields inspired by domain-specific standards such as the *Categories for the Description of Works of Art (CDWA)* and *VRA Core*, both of which emphasise materiality, technique, and spatial context in the documentation of visual culture (CDWA, 2015; VRA Core 4.0, 2024).

The resulting data model adopts an object-oriented structure in which each row represents a single graffiti work and its corresponding photograph, and each column corresponds to a distinct metadata element. Core descriptive fields—such as title, description, subject, and workType—align with *Dublin Core*'s emphasis on content and contextual information (Gilliland, 2016). Additional fields extend this schema to capture characteristics specific to graffiti as an immovable, urban cultural object, including material, technique, and multiple forms of spatial metadata (**location**, **location.site**, **location.creation**, **location.documentation**). This granularity reflects best practices in visual-culture documentation, where distinguishing between the physical work, its environment, and the circumstances of its capture is essential (CDWA, 2015; VRA Core 4.0, 2024).

The catalogue also incorporates structured identifiers and controlled vocabularies to support consistency and long-term interoperability. The workID / imageID field follows a stable naming convention (e.g., **GRAFFITI_ViennaTrashBin**), enabling reliable cross-referencing between the catalogue and Omeka. Controlled terms are used for fields such as workType, imageType, and relation (type = collection), aligning with recommendations for metadata standardisation in digital collections (Miller, 2022). Rights information is deliberately separated into rights and image.source, distinguishing between the legal status of the graffiti and the provenance of the photographic documentation—an important consideration in projects involving public, often anonymous artistic production (Watkins & Beaver, 2008).

Because the catalogue uses a hybrid schema—combining Dublin Core with custom fields tailored to graffiti—an accompanying mapping table clarifies how each local field corresponds to Dublin Core elements. For example, agent (role=artist) maps to Creator, material maps to Format or Description, and **location.creation** maps to Coverage. This mapping ensures that the enhanced descriptive richness required to document urban graffiti remains compatible with Omeka's Dublin Core-based infrastructure and broader metadata exchange practices (Gilliland, 2016; Miller, 2022).

References

CDWA (Categories for the Description of Works of Art). (2015). *CDWA Full*. Getty Research Institute. https://www.getty.edu/research/publications/electronic_publications/cdwa/

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Miller, S. J. (2022). *Metadata for digital collections* (2nd ed.). Facet Publishing.

VRA Core 4.0. (2024). *VRA Core: A data standard for the description of works of visual culture*. Visual Resources Association. <https://vraweb.org/resources/vra-core/>

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